pursuing a more scholarly existence. Shaikh Mubarak Nagauri, the learned theologian, scholar, and Mahdavi* sympathizer, had established his madrasa in Agra and was imparting to his two young sons, ten-year-old Abu'l Fazl and his elder brother Faizi, a rigorous and uncompromising education. The Mahdavi movement blazed through the sixteenth century with its emphasis on a direct experience of God and a forsaking of worldly desires. As the new Islamic millennium grew closer, there was a fervent belief that at the end of the first thousand years of Islam, a new Mahdi, or Imam, would be born into the world and he would 'restore the sinking faith to its pristine freshness'. This would be followed, it was believed, by the Day of Judgement and the end of the world, calculated at 1591. Shaikh Mubarak's particular stream of Mahdavi beliefs revolved around a Sufi-tinged belief in a series of mystical numbers. 'With his powerful knowledge and practice,' wrote Abu'l Fazl about his father, 'he did not allow me to associate with wayward, disreputable people, and he constantly guarded over me with advice to maintain inner purity, external cleanliness, an eloquent tongue and a pleasing manner of experience.' This was no ordinary childhood for Abu'l Fazl, who admitted that 'from the beginning I did not play hide-and-go-seek like a child, for my mother and my father were my guardians'. Abu'l Fazl's childhood was also unusual for a more sinister reason. Shaikh Mubarak had been persecuted by the ulema of the Sur court for his freewheeling eclecticism and this led to the family being hounded from their home. Shaikh Mubarak had finally migrated to Gujarat, on the advice of a Sufi shaikh, Salim Chishti, and the family had to live in hiding for a while when some within the ulema even asked for Shaikh Mubarak to be executed.* For the sensitive and talented young sons of Shaikh Mubarak, these difficult years would forever be remembered and a careful tally made of the men who had sought their father's destruction.

There was another student at Shaikh Mubarak's madrasa, a twenty-year-old highly intelligent and spiritually minded young man called Abd al-Qadir Badauni. Badauni would later write of Shaikh Mubarak's orthodox Sunni piety, at this point of his life: 'In early life he observed many austerities…'[I]f any body was present while he was giving religious instruction wearing a golden ring, or silk clothing, or red hose, or red or yellow garments, he at once made him remove the item, and if anyone appeared with long breeches descending below the heel, he immediately